

Heather Manley, Thlee'wee,

Aboriginal and Treaty Rights Litigation 2018

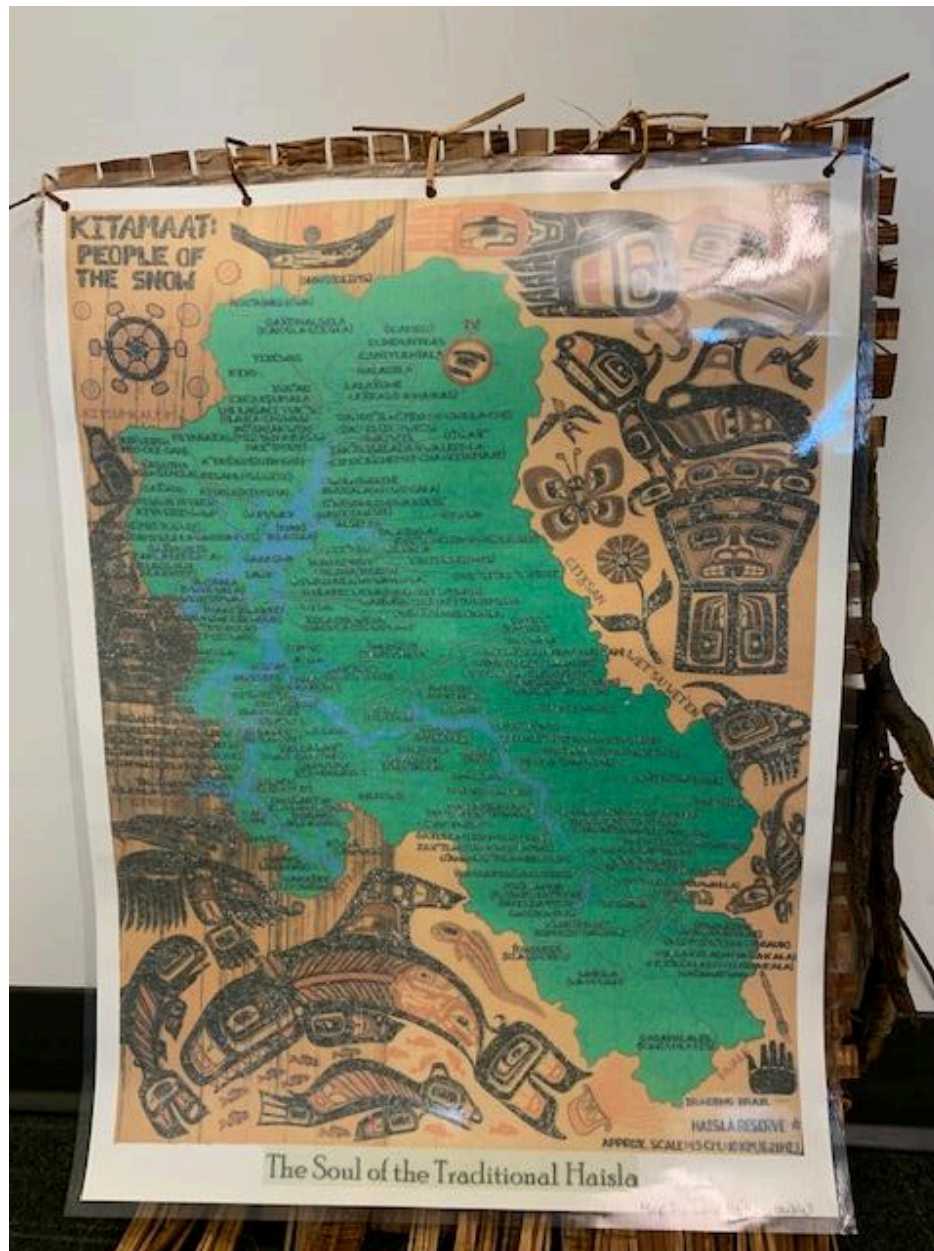
Weaving with copper, abalone shells and dried oolichans

This is a personal and unique piece. I feel privileged to have been able to create it. This piece made me reflect on all of the teachings I have received from my family, from her own people, about who I am and where I come from. I look forward to of the teachings that are still to come

This piece has also made me reflect on all that you have told me, starting with Aboriginal Constitutional Law in my first year law school, followed by Penal Policy and Ending with Aboriginal Title Litigation this Year.

I have woven together all these teachings and, in the process, I have contemplated what role I might play in the reconciliation of Aboriginal Title and Rights as a soon-to-be Indigenous lawyer.

It has been a joy and a privilege to be one of your students.

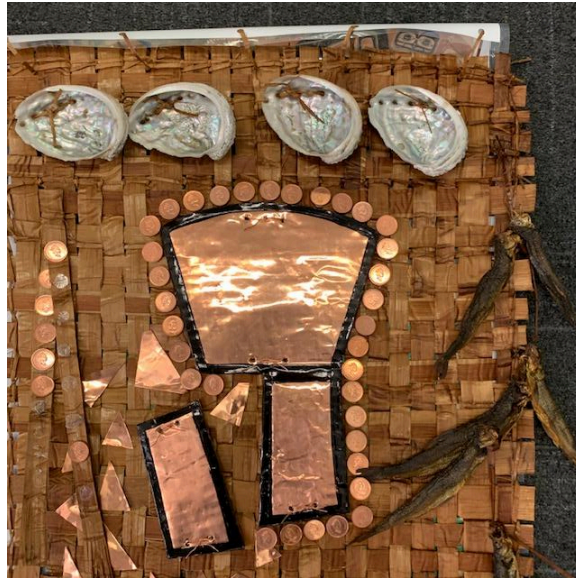




I have woven this mat, this thlee'wee (a mat used on the floor by our old people in the olden days) like my Great Granny Angeline would have when she was a girl. It represents the interconnectedness of my people with our land. The smoked and dried oolichan hanging on the side represent my Nation's creation story. Oolichans and oolichan grease were our peoples' mainstay for hundreds of years. Not only did oolichans sustain us but we traded it with other nations. It was our economy as well.

The copper shield represents a trade good, and at times, copper from our territories, that our people received in exchange for fish and furs. The copper shield is a symbol of power and wealth. It is also a symbol of justice and truth. It is an integral part of our feasting system within my Nation. Breaking copper at a feast was done for a variety of reasons. It was often broken into pieces and shared with others by the Heymas, the Chief, who owned it, as a sign of sharing the wealth. It was also used in shaming ceremonies in order for reconciliation, between two parties or Nations, to occur. I have used the symbolism of a broken copper shield and copper pieces to demonstrate the sharing of wealth our people engaged in and to demonstrate shame on the behaviour of the Crown for the theft of our lands, the cultural genocide of our people and for the manner in

which the colonial justice system continues to treat our Nations. A justice system that fails, repeatedly, to demonstrate recognition and respect for Aboriginal title and rights.



The penny also represents the British Crown, Her Majesty the Queen, whose colonial system claims sovereignty over all of Canada. In contrast the copper shield tells us that we are our own sovereign nations

The oolican design is made out of wool melton and along with the abalone buttons, it represents the beautiful ceremonial robes, Button Blankets, that our people proudly wear at feasts. The blankets display our family crests. They tell the story of who we are and where we come from. They are robes of power. The abalone shells, fastened at the top of the thlee'wee, are representative of our traditional food. We used the beautiful shells as adornment for our Button Blankets and for jewelry.

I am a proud member of the Fish Clan. Along with the creative DNA I have inherited from my Great Granny Angeline, I know that my determination and resiliency comes from the continued struggle of my people to survive. That struggle to survive is witnessed by our salmon relations, on their journey up river. A journey fraught with obstacles and seemingly insurmountable challenges along the way. The same, seemingly insurmountable obstacles and challenges, that colonial courts throw in way of our people, in one case after the other, on our journey to prove that the land is ours and that we hold too.